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Create Connected Learning Communities
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I have given a lot of thought to section V of the Gates book. From the beginning of the book, Bill Gates has taken us from global information technology to the Internet and then to strategy and business operations. And now, Bill Gates has completely gone off on a different tangent with the managed health care model. My initial reaction: how does managed health care have to do anything with running a business, and how does technology fit into this model? Perhaps Bill Gates is trying to show us that anything and everything can be interconnected with the digital nervous system, as he described in the first chapter (pg. 15). I have gained a much broader perspective on what he means in chapter 22—Create Connected Learning Communities. In fact, this is the same concept as the college model at Ohlone College.

The business of health care is not about information technology, but it is the technology that helps run the day-to-day of a business. It becomes much clearer to me when Bill Gates talks about the business of providing health care and the high cost. There are just too many different organizations—the hospital or doctor's office, the pharmacy, the social agency, Medicare, the insurance company, and so on. Many of these organizations are very disjointed, and there are just too many human-factors errors. Bill Gates said that about 20 to 30 percent of the annual trillion-dollar cost of the U.S. health care system is tied to paperwork (pg. 395). Bill Gates is saying that the health care industry is no different than in almost any other industry. For most businesses today, they want to reduce costs, ensure consistency, improve customer service, and increase revenue. This is the managed care model. According to Bill Gates, the U.S.

health care industry has shifted to “managed care” to reduce costs, prevent fraud, and ensure consistent and appropriate care (pg. 335). Bill Gates says that information technology can help transform health care business operations.

Does paperwork and complexity have anything to do with information technology? Yes. It has everything to do with information technology. The necessary software and hardware, control devices, and digital equipment are integral to any business operations. There is just no way to process billions of documents without a computer, printer, fax, copier, scanner, and so on. In addition, there are just too many human-factor errors and too many processes. I feel that operating a health care system is like operating a digital nervous system. According to Bill Gates, a digital nervous system comprises the digital processes that closely link every aspect of a company’s thoughts and actions (pg. 15).

I liked the initial quote in chapter 20, “we must empower citizens to act for themselves without having to go through a bureaucracy” (pg. 357), and I agreed. I also liked what Bill Gates said about replacing paper flow with digital publishing, providing an accessible face to government, and providing access to every citizen. One of the intents of the Internet is making it available to the public, and it must be free from government regulation. Similarly, Wi-Fi provides wireless Internet access, and there is a growing trend to expand access to this technology and free Wi-Fi services. Google is a good example of offering free Wi-Fi service to early test subscribers.

Bill Gates ended section V with “Create connected learning communities,” and it sounded so much like the Learning College model at Ohlone College. Learning Communities are curricular structures that intentionally restructure the curriculum to

bring students, faculty, and disciplines together in more integrated and meaningful ways.

This is what the Internet is all about and how people are getting together and connecting.